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**BS-Computer Engineering 2A**

21<sup>st</sup> Century IT Skills – Lab 8

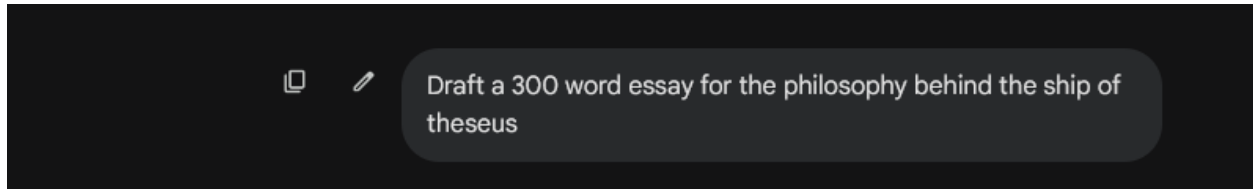
# ***AI Tool Prompt Engineering Report***

## What will be used, and what's the goal?

**Google Gemini** is a multi-purpose LLM. For this experiment, Gemini, and its 'fast' thinking mode will be used. This is the most accessible option, *because of its AdDU account integration*. As for why I chose the 'fast' option, I wanted to see how good a "simple" output would be.

This LLM's goal is to make me a draft about the Ship of Theseus.

### Attempt 1: Basic Prompt (I interact with AI at a surface level)



### Output:

The Ship of Theseus is more than a maritime relic; it is a profound ontological puzzle that challenges our most basic assumptions about identity and persistence. As the wooden planks of the legendary vessel decayed and were replaced one by one, the Greeks asked a deceptively simple question: If every single component of an object is eventually substituted, is it still the same object?

#### The Conflict of Continuity

At the heart of this paradox lies a clash between two different ways of defining "sameness":

- **Spatio-temporal Continuity:** This view suggests that identity is a continuous chain. Because the ship occupied the same space and maintained its form throughout the gradual repairs, it remains the Ship of Theseus.
- **Constitutional Identity:** This view argues that an object is the sum of its parts. If the original atoms and wood are gone, the "essence" of the original ship has vanished with them.

#### The Problem of Reassembly

The philosopher Thomas Hobbes later intensified the dilemma by imagining a scavenger who collected the old, discarded planks and built a second ship. We are then left with two candidates for the title: one that has the functional history (the repaired ship) and one that has the original matter (the reassembled ship). Logic dictates that one thing cannot be in two places at once, yet both ships have a valid claim to being the "original."

#### Human Implications

The true weight of the paradox is felt when we apply it to ourselves. Human cells are constantly dying and regenerating; our memories fade and our personalities shift. If identity relies on unchanging matter, "you" cease to exist every few years.

Ultimately, the Ship of Theseus suggests that identity might not be an inherent property of the universe, but a narrative construct. We label things as "the same" to make sense of a world in constant flux, choosing to prioritize the "story" of the ship over the cold reality of its shifting physical parts.

## Attempt 2: ENHANCED Prompt

ChatGPT ▾

✦ Get Plus ✕

I want to give Google Gemini an efficient prompt that will provide a 300-word essay on the philosophy behind the Ship of Theseus. Could you help me refine this by asking for 3 sets of options on how the prompt will be improved?

Absolutely—good idea to optimize the prompt first. I'll give you **3 different improved prompt styles**, each with a slightly different strategy (precision, structure, and creativity), so you can choose what works best with Google Gemini.

### ◆ Option Set 1: Clear & Direct (High Reliability)

This version is straightforward and minimizes ambiguity.

Write a 300-word essay explaining the philosophy behind the Ship of Theseus.  
Focus on the concept of identity over time, and discuss how the paradox raises questions about it.  
Use clear, concise language suitable for a general audience.  
Avoid unnecessary jargon and ensure the essay has a logical flow with an introduction, body, and conclusion.



Why this works:

- Sets exact word count
- Defines topic scope
- Controls tone and structure

### ◆ Option Set 2: Structured & Academic (More Polished Output)

This version pushes for a more refined, academic-style answer.

Compose a well-structured 300-word essay on the philosophical implications of the Ship of Theseus. Include a brief introduction to the paradox, followed by an analysis of key themes such as identity and change. Reference at least one philosophical perspective or interpretation, and conclude with a thoughtful reflection. Maintain a formal academic tone throughout.

Why this works:

- Encourages deeper analysis
- Adds intellectual framing
- Produces more "school-ready" content

### ◆ Option Set 3: Engaging & Insightful (More Human-like Writing)

This version aims for a more engaging, readable essay.

Write an engaging 300-word essay exploring the philosophy behind the Ship of Theseus. Begin with a compelling explanation of the paradox, then examine what it reveals about identity and change. Use relatable examples or analogies to make the concept easier to understand, while still maintaining intellectual depth. End with a reflective conclusion that invites the reader to think further.

Why this works:

- Produces more natural, readable writing
- Adds storytelling/analogy
- Better for presentations or blogs

In the end, I went with Option 3, for more natural writing.

Inputting this prompt into Gemini, what returns is this:

If you replace every plank of a wooden ship, one by one, until not a single original splinter remains, is it still the same ship? This is the **Ship of Theseus**, a classic philosophical paradox that has forced thinkers from Plutarch to modern neuroscientists to reckon with the elusive nature of identity.

At first glance, common sense says "yes." We don't discard our sense of self just because we get a haircut. However, the paradox deepens if we imagine a scavenger collecting all the old, discarded planks and reassembling them into a second ship. Now, we have two vessels: one with the original "form" and one with the original "matter." Which one is the *real* Ship of Theseus?

This puzzle reveals that our concept of identity is often a mental construct rather than a physical fact. We tend to view identity through two different lenses:

- **Continuity of Form:** The idea that something remains the same as long as its structure and function persist.
- **Continuity of Substance:** The belief that identity is tied to the specific "stuff" an object is made of.

Consider a more personal analogy: **the human body**.

Biologically, your cells are in a constant state of regeneration. The skin you inhabit today isn't the same skin you wore ten years ago. Yet, you likely feel like the same "you" because your memories, personality, and consciousness—your "form"—provide a bridge across time.

Ultimately, the Ship of Theseus suggests that identity is not a static destination but a **narrative process**. If identity were purely material, we would be strangers to ourselves every few years. If it were purely structural, the second ship built from scraps would be a mere fraud. Perhaps identity isn't found in the planks or the blueprints, but in the journey the ship takes. If everything about you changed tomorrow, what "original plank" would you fight to keep?

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Okay, it is now time to make comparisons between the two outputs.

Between the two outputs, there is no denying that there are significant improvements to the output after having been enhanced. Of the many differences, the main difference is the reduction of common patterns that were picked up by Google Gemini. That very change is prevalent, even within **the first sentence of the updated draft!** Instead of leaning towards that “It’s not x, it’s y” format, Google Gemini chooses to create a more profound introduction. Additionally, there is also an absence of categories in the second prompt.

Something that helped this draft become enhanced was the fact that, in the prompt, structure was designated. The definition was made clear: the draft needs an introduction, body, and a conclusion that needed to make people think. Because of those details in structure, the generated prompt has a much clearer vision on what steps to take and how to write, which reduces bullet points, avoids random tangents, and provides coherence and cohesiveness to the new text. This goes to show how defining structure can be the make-or-break in your generation.

Speaking of structure, something important that I realized about prompting is that **structure and context can make a better prompt.** A fatal mistake that I make more often than I’d like to admit is that I assume that the AI knows how to do EVERYTHING. For example, if I want to create code for a project, I assume that if I just send a photo, or a long string of text, to an LLM like Claude, it can generate some functional and ready-to-publish code, without any errors or polish issues whatsoever. As it turns out, the process needs much more detail, and works much better when done step-by-step. There are, in fact, levels to this...